DSEH004 · PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT

Sponsorship, Meritocracy and the Round 5 Brief

Week 9 · Lecture 3 · Kram, social capital, the paradox of meritocracy and fair advancement

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L3 · SPONSORSHIP AND EQUITY

Meritocracy is a design claim, not a description.

L3 · COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Two engineers are both rated 4.5. One is given a stretch assignment after a senior leader speaks for her in a meeting she did not attend. Is that merit?

Yes, no, or merit plus something else. If something else, name it.

L3 · THE ORIGINAL THEORY

Kram (1985): the two functions of mentoring

CAREER FUNCTIONS	PSYCHOSOCIAL FUNCTIONS
Sponsorship	Role modeling
Exposure and visibility	Acceptance and confirmation
Coaching	Counseling
Protection	Friendship
Challenging assignments	

Sponsorship was always part of mentoring. The modern debate is about which function people actually receive.

Kram, K. E. (1985). Mentoring at Work. Scott Foresman

L3 · DOES MENTORING WORK?

Eby, Allen, Evans, Ng and DuBois (2008)

The finding

Mentoring is associated with better behavioral, attitudinal, health, motivational and career outcomes.

The size

Most effects are small. Mentoring helps, but it is not the large lever programs often promise.

Small average effects suggest the active ingredient varies. Ibarra, Carter and Silva (2010) argue women received mentoring but less sponsorship.

Eby et al. (2008), Journal of Vocational Behavior, 72(2), 254 to 267; Ibarra, Carter and Silva (2010), Harvard Business Review

A social capital theory of career success

GRANOVETTER (1973)

Weak ties

Acquaintances bring information that close contacts do not already have.

BURT (1992)

Structural holes

People who bridge unconnected groups gain early information and control.

SEIBERT, KRAIMER AND LIDEN (2001)

The pathway

Network structure leads to access to information, resources and career sponsorship, which lead to salary, promotion and satisfaction.

A sponsor spends their own social capital on you. That is why sponsorship is scarce, and why it is unequally distributed.

What happens when a firm says it rewards merit

CASTILLA (2008), AMERICAN JOURNAL OF SOCIOLOGY

Same rating, different raise

Employees with equal performance ratings received different salary increases by gender and race.

CASTILLA AND BENARD (2010), ADMINISTRATIVE SCIENCE QUARTERLY

The paradox

In experiments, framing an organization as meritocratic led managers to favor men over equally performing women.

CASTILLA (2015), ORGANIZATION SCIENCE

What reduced the gap

Making pay decisions transparent and making managers accountable for them.

The problem with judging potential

SILZER AND CHURCH (2009)

Performance and potential

A nine box grid asks raters to judge potential, which is less observable than performance.

MCKINSEY AND LEANIN.ORG (2019)

The broken rung

In 2019, 72 women were promoted to first level manager for every 100 men; the gap opens at the first step.

LEVENTHAL (1980)

Leventhal returns

Consistency, accuracy, correctability and representation are tests a review can fail. Recall Week 8.

Option 5E is a calibrated talent review. Which of Leventhal's rules does calibration protect, and which can it break?

L3 · ROUND 5 BRIEF

Strengths and career: the trade off you must name

OPTION	THE THEORY IT RESTS ON
5A Strengths assessment and deployment	Clifton; feedback intervention theory
5B Job crafting enablement	Wrzesniewski and Dutton; content plateau
5C Internal talent marketplace	Internal labor markets; posting versus slotting
5D Dual career ladder	Peter principle; Allen and Katz
5E Calibrated talent review and succession	Potential judgments; justice

Decision focus: name the deployment, development and mobility trade off, with a concrete next step for at least three of the four anchors. Costs and balances: the portal is the authority.

L3 · STRESS TEST

Four anchors, read through this week's theories

ANCHOR	QUESTION YOUR DESIGN MUST ANSWER
BT 2026100 · Gen Z · Sales · 4 months	Does a strengths conversation reach her before she leaves?
BT 2026200 · Engineering · 7 years	Which plateau is it, and which port opens for him?
BT 2026300 · Engineering · rated 4.5	Who sponsors him, and is the sponsorship fair to peers?
BT 2026400 · QC · 22.5 years	Does a technical ladder honor him or sideline him?

Anchors from the Project Pratibha character set

BEFORE WEEK 10

Preparation

1 **Read**
Eby et al. (2008) and Pfeffer (1998), Chapter 2.

2 **Forum**
Find one Indian organization with a published internal mobility program. What did it disclose, and what would you need to see that it did not?

3 **Round 5**
Your pod's justification must name the theory behind its choice. Check Classroom for the closing time.

4 **Revise**
Earlier weeks remain in scope for every quiz and for the End Term.

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